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06

WEEKS

6-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

Press Like A Boss

Upper-body strength for women: a stronger press, back and shoulders.

Tap to open the interactive program →

Danielle Dawson

6 WEEKS · 3 DAYS/WEEK · 18 WORKOUTS

How to use this book

This book is the companion to your interactive app. The app is the fastest way to train: it logs every set, remembers your weights, runs your rest timer and charts your progress. This PDF gives you the same material in a format you can read, print and fill in.

Tap here to open your interactive program →

The interactive program tracks every set, runs your rest timer, charts your progress and includes every chapter with quizzes. On your phone, tap *Share → Add to Home Screen* so it opens like an app.

This PDF is interactive. Tap any entry in the table of contents to jump to it, use your PDF reader's bookmarks panel to navigate, and fill in the workbook pages at the back directly in Adobe Acrobat, Apple Books/Preview, or most PDF apps. Your entries save with the file.

This program is for educational purposes and is not medical advice. Consult your doctor before starting a new exercise or nutrition plan, especially if you are pregnant, injured or have a medical condition. Stop any exercise that causes pain.

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PART I

The Handbook

11 chapters. Read Chapters 1–4 before you start, and use the rest as a reference.

CHAPTER 1

Welcome & How This Program Works

Y'all saw me press 70s and 75s. This is the program that got me there. It's a 6-week upper-body strength block built around one goal: **getting your dumbbell press as strong as possible**, while building sculpted shoulders, a strong back and toned arms along the way.

The structure

DAY	SESSION	FOCUS
Day 1	Heavy Push	Heavy flat & incline pressing, shoulders, triceps
Day 2	Pull + Posture	Lats, mid-back, rear delts, biceps
Day 3	Volume Push	Paused presses, chest isolation, shoulders, triceps

Run it on its own (3 days/week), or pair it with lower-body days for a 5–6 day split. If you're also running the Glute Specialist Program, replace that program's Day 2 (Upper Body) with these three days.

The phases

WEEKS	PHASE	MAIN LIFT SETS × REPS	TARGET RIR
1–2	Foundation	3 × 10	2–3
3–4	Build	4 × 8	1–2
5	Strength	5 × 5	1–2
6	PR Week	Work up to a heavy 3	1

> **Coach's note:** Strength is a skill. Pressing the same movement three times a week with perfect technique is how you get strong fast. Don't swap the main lifts. Own them.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

If you're also running the Glute Specialist Program, which day should these 3 days replace?

A. Day 1 Glute Strength

B. Day 2 Upper Body

C. None, just add them all

Answer: B. These three upper days replace the single upper-body day, giving you a complete upper/lower split.

CHAPTER 2

Upper-Body Anatomy for Women Who Lift

Chest (pectoralis major)

Your pecs push your arms forward and across your body. The **upper (clavicular) chest** is trained more by incline pressing. The **mid/lower chest** is trained by flat pressing and flyes. A developed chest doesn't make you "bulky". It lifts and shapes your upper body and supports your posture.

Shoulders (deltoids)

Three heads: **front** (pressing), **side** (lateral raises, which give the "capped" look and make your waist look smaller), and **rear** (face pulls, rear delt flyes, which pull your shoulders back for better posture).

Triceps

Two-thirds of your upper arm. Strong triceps help your press and tone the back of the arm. The **long head** is trained best with your arm overhead (overhead extensions).

Back (lats, rhomboids, traps)

Your back is the base you press from. A strong upper back keeps your shoulder blades stable on the bench, which makes you stronger and protects your shoulders. Your lats also create the V-taper that makes your waist look smaller.

> **The balance rule:** For every pressing set, do roughly one pulling set. This program keeps that balance, which is why Day 2 is not optional.

CHAPTER 3

Dumbbell Press Masterclass

The dumbbell press is the backbone of this program. Here's how to do it like a pro.

Getting heavy dumbbells into position (the kick-up)

1. Sit on the end of the bench with the dumbbells standing upright on your thighs, close to your knees.
2. Grip them firmly and take a breath.
3. Lie back in one smooth motion, and as you roll back, drive one knee up into one dumbbell, then the other (or both at once), popping them to your chest.
4. Your momentum carries the dumbbells into the start position.

The setup

- **Shoulder blades:** pinch them together and pull them down, like tucking them into your back pockets. Keep them there for every rep.
- **Arch:** a natural arch in your lower back is safe and helps you press. Your glutes stay on the bench.
- **Feet:** planted flat, pushing into the floor (leg drive).
- **Wrists:** stacked over your elbows, knuckles toward the ceiling.

The rep

1. Start with the dumbbells over your shoulders.
2. Lower them toward your lower chest over about 2 seconds, with your elbows about **45°** from your torso.
3. At the bottom, the dumbbells are roughly level with your chest and your forearms are vertical.
4. Press up and slightly in, so the dumbbells finish above your shoulders. They don't need to touch.

Getting out of the set safely

Bring the dumbbells to your chest, tuck your knees up and rock forward to sit up with the dumbbells resting on your thighs. **Never drop heavy dumbbells out to the sides.** It's dangerous for your shoulders and annoying for everyone around you.

Common mistakes

MISTAKE	FIX
Elbows flared to 90°	Tuck to 45°. It's stronger and kinder to your shoulders
Shoulders rolling forward at the top	Keep shoulder blades pinned. Stop the press just short of reaching
Bouncing at the bottom	Control the lowering, brief pause, then press
Feet floating	Plant your feet and push them into the floor
Dumbbells drifting toward your face	Press over your shoulders, lower to your lower chest

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

What elbow angle should you use on dumbbell presses?

A. 90°, straight out to the sides

B. About 45° from your torso

C. Elbows touching your ribs

Answer: B. About 45° is strong and shoulder-friendly. Flaring to 90° puts more stress on the front of the shoulder.

CHAPTER 4

The Dumbbell Jump Problem (and How to Beat It)

Here's the challenge nobody talks about: dumbbells usually go up in 5 lb increments **per hand**. Going from 25s to 30s is a **20% jump**, which is huge. This is where most women get stuck.

Solution 1: Double progression with a wide rep range

Stay with a weight until you can do **every set at the top of the rep range**, then move up. The extra reps build the strength you need to handle the jump.

Solution 2: The "one set heavier" bridge

When you're ready to jump weights but can't hit all your sets:

SESSION	SET 1	SETS 2–4
A	30s × 6	25s × 10
B	30s × 7	25s × 10
C	30s × 8, 30s × 6	25s × 10
D	All sets with 30s ✅	

Solution 3: Slow it down

Add a 3-second lowering phase or a 2-second pause. The same weight becomes much harder, so you build strength without needing a heavier dumbbell.

Solution 4: Microloading

Some gyms have 2.5 lb dumbbell increments or magnetic add-on weights. If yours does, use them.

> **Coach's note:** It took me months to get from the 50s to the 70s. Every 5 lb jump is a real achievement. Celebrate each one and log it on your PR Wall.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Going from 25 lb to 30 lb dumbbells is roughly what percentage jump?

A. 5%

B. 10%

C. 20%

Answer: C. 5 ÷ 25 = 20%. That's why wide rep ranges and the 'one set heavier' bridge matter.

CHAPTER 5

Shoulder Health & Injury Prevention

Pressing heavy is safe when you do it right. These habits keep your shoulders healthy for years.

Warm-up for every push day (5 minutes)

1. Band pull-aparts × 15
2. Band external rotations × 12 each arm
3. Arm circles forward and back × 10
4. Push-ups × 8–10 (on knees or incline is fine)
5. Ramp-up sets on your first press (see the Warm-Up Calculator in Tools)

The rules

- **Pull as much as you push.** Face pulls and rows protect your shoulders.
- **Don't press through pain.** Sharp or pinching pain in the front of the shoulder means stop. Try a neutral grip (palms facing each other), a lower range, or a machine press instead.
- **Control the bottom.** Shoulders are most vulnerable at the deepest point. Never bounce there.

Neutral-grip pressing

If regular dumbbell presses bother your shoulders, try pressing with your palms facing each other. Most people can press pain-free this way, and it's just as effective for the chest and triceps.

CHAPTER 6

Training Your Back for a Bigger Press

A strong back gives you a stable platform to press from, and it creates the posture and V-taper that makes your waist look snatched.

Key principles

- **Pull with your elbows, not your hands.** Imagine your hands are hooks.
- **Full stretch, full squeeze.** Let your shoulder blades move. Reach at the bottom of a row, squeeze at the top.
- **Control the lowering.** Two to three seconds on every rep.

Back exercise effectiveness

EXERCISE	MAIN TARGET	WHY IT'S IN THE PROGRAM
Lat Pulldown	Lats	Width and V-taper, shoulder health
Single-Arm DB Row	Lats, mid-back	Fixes left/right imbalances
Face Pulls	Rear delts, rotator cuff	Posture and shoulder health
Rear Delt Fly	Rear delts	Balances all the pressing

CHAPTER 7

Spotting, Safety & Gym Confidence

When you need a spotter

During Weeks 5 and 6, your sets are heavy enough that a spotter helps. With dumbbells, the spotter should support your **wrists or forearms**, never your elbows.

How to ask for a spot

> "Hey, could you spot me for one set? It's [number] reps. Just help at the wrists if I get stuck."

Most regulars at the gym are happy to help. Asking is a sign that you take your training seriously.

If you get stuck without a spotter

Lower the dumbbells to your chest, bring your knees up, and roll up to sitting with the dumbbells on your thighs. Practice this with light weights so it's automatic.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Where should a spotter help on a dumbbell press?

A. At your elbows

B. At your wrists/forearms

C. By pushing your chest

Answer: B. Spotting at the wrists or forearms controls the dumbbells directly.

CHAPTER 8

Reading Your Effort (RIR)

RIR = Reps In Reserve: how many good reps you could still do when you stop.

RIR	FEELS LIKE
3	Challenging but fast
2	Hard. Reps slow down
1	Very hard. One rep left
0	Failure. Only on machines and isolation moves

On presses, stay at **RIR 1–2**. Missing a dumbbell press rep is how injuries happen. Save failure for cable flyes, pushdowns and lateral raises.

CHAPTER 9

PR Week Protocol

Week 6 is where you show off everything you've built. Here's how to test safely on Day 1.

Before PR day

- Sleep well for 2 nights before.
- Eat a solid carb + protein meal 2–3 hours before training.
- Bring a spotter or film the set.

The warm-up ladder

Use the Warm-Up Calculator in the Tools tab, or follow this pattern based on your target weight:

SET	WEIGHT	REPS	REST
1	~40%	10	1 min
2	~60%	5	1.5 min
3	~75%	3	2 min
4	~85%	2	2–3 min
5	~92%	1	3 min
6	**Target heavy 3**	3	3–4 min
7 (optional)	+5 lb per DB	1–3	—

Stop when the next set wouldn't be clean. A slow, grindy rep is fine. A rep where your form falls apart is not.

Log it

Enter your result on the **PR Wall**. The app calculates your estimated 1-rep max using the Epley formula: **weight × (1 + reps ÷ 30)**.

CHAPTER 10

Nutrition for Strength

- **Protein:** 0.7–1.0 g per lb of goal body weight daily.
- **Calories:** at least maintenance during this program. Strength is hard to build in a big deficit.
- **Carbs before training:** a carb + protein meal 1–3 hours before you press.
- **Creatine monohydrate:** 3–5 g daily is one of the best-researched supplements for strength.

See the **Fuel Like A Baddie** guide for complete macro calculations and meal plans.

CHAPTER 11

Frequently Asked Questions

Will lifting heavy make my arms bulky? No. Women build upper-body muscle slowly, partly because of lower testosterone. What you'll see is tighter, more defined shoulders and arms.

Can I use a barbell bench press instead? Yes, the principles are the same, but dumbbells are easier to learn, safer without a spotter and fix strength imbalances. That's why I use them.

My left side is weaker than my right. That's normal. Dumbbells will even it out over time. Let the weaker side set the reps.

How often should I test my max? Once per training block (every 6–8 weeks). Testing too often takes away from training.

What do I do after Week 6? Take an easy week, then rerun the program starting with weights about 5–10% heavier than your Week 1 weights.

PART II

The Program

Every workout, week by week. Log your sets in the app or in the fillable workbook at the back of this book.

Week 1

FOUNDATION PHASE

Choose a weight you could press 12–13 times and do 10 clean reps.

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	3 × 10	2–3	2 min
Incline DB Press	3 × 10	2–3	2 min
DB Shoulder Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Bench Dips	3 × 12	2	75s
Push-Ups	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	3 × 10	2–3	2 min
Single-Arm DB Row	3 × 10 /side	2–3	2 min
Face Pulls	3 × 12	2	75s
Rear Delt Fly	3 × 12	2	75s
Hammer Curl	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	3 × 10	2–3	2 min
Machine Chest Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Cable Fly	3 × 12	2	75s
Arnold Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Overhead Tricep Extension	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Week 2

FOUNDATION PHASE

If every rep was clean last week, go up 2.5–5 lb per dumbbell.

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	3 × 10	2	2 min
Incline DB Press	3 × 10	2	2 min
DB Shoulder Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Bench Dips	3 × 12	2	75s
Push-Ups	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	3 × 10	2	2 min
Single-Arm DB Row	3 × 10 /side	2	2 min
Face Pulls	3 × 12	2	75s
Rear Delt Fly	3 × 12	2	75s
Hammer Curl	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	3 × 10	2	2 min
Machine Chest Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Cable Fly	3 × 12	2	75s
Arnold Press	3 × 12	2	75s
Overhead Tricep Extension	2 × AMRAP	1	60s

Week 3

BUILD PHASE

Heavier with an extra set. Use the kick-up technique from Chapter 3.

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	4 × 8	2	2.5 min
Incline DB Press	4 × 8	2	2.5 min
DB Shoulder Press	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Bench Dips	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Push-Ups	3 × AMRAP	0–1	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	4 × 8	2	2.5 min
Single-Arm DB Row	4 × 8 /side	2	2.5 min
Face Pulls	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Rear Delt Fly	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Hammer Curl	3 × AMRAP	0–1	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	4 × 8	2	2.5 min
Machine Chest Press	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Cable Fly	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Arnold Press	3 × 10	1–2	75s
Overhead Tricep Extension	3 × AMRAP	0–1	60s

Week 4

BUILD PHASE

Beat Week 3 by a rep or use the one-set-heavier bridge (Chapter 4).

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	4 × 8	1–2	2.5 min
Incline DB Press	4 × 8	1–2	2.5 min
DB Shoulder Press	3 × 10	1	75s
Bench Dips	3 × 10	1	75s
Push-Ups	3 × AMRAP	0	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	4 × 8	1–2	2.5 min
Single-Arm DB Row	4 × 8 /side	1–2	2.5 min
Face Pulls	3 × 10	1	75s
Rear Delt Fly	3 × 10	1	75s
Hammer Curl	3 × AMRAP	0	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	4 × 8	1–2	2.5 min
Machine Chest Press	3 × 10	1	75s
Cable Fly	3 × 10	1	75s
Arnold Press	3 × 10	1	75s
Overhead Tricep Extension	3 × AMRAP	0	60s

Week 5

STRENGTH PHASE

Heavy fives. Spotter or filming recommended.

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	5 × 5	1–2	3 min
Incline DB Press	5 × 5	1–2	3 min
DB Shoulder Press	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Bench Dips	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Push-Ups	2 × AMRAP	0	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	5 × 5	1–2	3 min
Single-Arm DB Row	5 × 5 /side	1–2	3 min
Face Pulls	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Rear Delt Fly	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Hammer Curl	2 × AMRAP	0	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	5 × 5	1–2	3 min
Machine Chest Press	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Cable Fly	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Arnold Press	3 × 8–10	1–2	90s
Overhead Tricep Extension	2 × AMRAP	0	60s

Week 6

PR WEEK PHASE

Day 1: follow the PR Week Protocol (Chapter 10) and work up to a heavy 3. Log it on the PR Wall.

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
DB Chest Press	4 × Heavy 3	1	3 min
Incline DB Press	4 × Heavy 3	1	3 min
DB Shoulder Press	2 × 10	2	90s
Bench Dips	2 × 10	2	90s
Push-Ups	1 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Lat Pulldown	4 × Heavy 3	1	3 min
Single-Arm DB Row	4 × Heavy 3 /side	1	3 min
Face Pulls	2 × 10	2	90s
Rear Delt Fly	2 × 10	2	90s
Hammer Curl	1 × AMRAP	1	60s

Day 3 · Volume Push

Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RIR	REST
Paused DB Bench Press	4 × Heavy 3	1	3 min
Machine Chest Press	2 × 10	2	90s
Cable Fly	2 × 10	2	90s
Arnold Press	2 × 10	2	90s
Overhead Tricep Extension	1 × AMRAP	1	60s

PART III

Exercise Library

Setup, execution, cues, common mistakes and swaps for all 15 exercises in this program.

Arnold Press

Upper · Front & side delts, triceps · Equipment: Dumbbells, bench

SETUP

1. Sit upright with dumbbells at chin height, palms facing you.

CUES

- Smooth rotation

EASIER / HARDER

DB Shoulder Press / Standing Arnold Press

EXECUTION

1. Rotate your palms forward as you press overhead.
2. Reverse the rotation on the way down.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Arching the back

SWAPS

DB Shoulder Press

Bench Dips

Upper · Triceps, chest · Equipment: Bench

SETUP

1. Sit on the edge of a bench, hands beside your hips, then slide off with legs bent or straight.

CUES

- Shoulders down and back
- Stay close to the bench

EASIER / HARDER

Bend your knees more / Feet elevated

EXECUTION

1. Lower by bending your elbows until about 90°.
2. Press back up through your palms.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Going too deep and straining the front of the shoulder
- Shrugging

SWAPS

Tricep Rope Pushdown, Close-Grip Push-Up

Cable Fly

Upper · Pecs · Equipment: Cable crossover

SETUP

1. Set both pulleys at shoulder height, grab the handles and step forward into a staggered stance.

CUES

- Hug a tree
- Stretch on the way back

EASIER / HARDER

Pec Deck / Low-to-high fly

EXECUTION

1. With a slight elbow bend, bring your hands together in front of your chest.
2. Return slowly to a deep stretch.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Turning it into a press
- Going too heavy

SWAPS

Pec Deck, DB Fly

DB Chest Press

Upper · Pecs, front delts, triceps · Equipment: Flat bench, dumbbells

SETUP

1. Sit on the end of the bench with the dumbbells standing on your thighs.
2. Lie back and use your knees to 'kick' the dumbbells up to your chest, one at a time if needed.
3. Pinch your shoulder blades together and down, plant your feet, and keep a slight natural arch.

EXECUTION

1. Press the dumbbells up and slightly together until your arms are straight (not locked hard).
2. Lower under control to chest level with elbows about 45° from your body.
3. At the bottom, the dumbbells should be roughly in line with your lower chest.
4. Press up again, keeping your shoulder blades pinned the whole time.

CUES

- Shoulder blades in your back pockets
- Elbows at 45°, not flared at 90°
- Push yourself away from the dumbbells

COMMON MISTAKES

- Flaring the elbows straight out
- Losing the shoulder-blade position at the top
- Bouncing at the bottom
- Dropping the dumbbells out to the sides after the set

EASIER / HARDER

Machine Chest Press or Push-Ups / Paused DB Bench Press or 3-sec lowering

SWAPS

Barbell Bench Press, Machine Chest Press, Smith Machine Press

DB Shoulder Press

Upper · Front & side delts, triceps, upper chest · Equipment: Adjustable bench, dumbbells

SETUP

1. Set the bench upright (about 80–90°).
2. Kick the dumbbells up to shoulder height, palms facing forward or slightly in.

EXECUTION

1. Press up and slightly in until your arms are nearly straight.
2. Lower until the dumbbells are about ear level.
3. Keep your ribs down and your back on the pad.

CUES

- Ribs down
- Press up and in
- Forearms vertical

COMMON MISTAKES

- Arching the back to turn it into an incline press
- Lowering too far and losing tension
- Clanking the dumbbells together

EASIER / HARDER

Machine Shoulder Press / Standing DB Press

SWAPS

Machine Shoulder Press, Arnold Press, Landmine Press

Face Pulls

Upper · Rear delts, upper back, rotator cuff · Equipment: Cable, rope

SETUP

1. Set the pulley at upper chest to face height and attach a rope.

EXECUTION

1. Pull the rope toward your eyebrows, splitting it apart.
2. Rotate your hands back so your knuckles face the ceiling at the end.
3. Return slowly.

CUES

- Elbows high
- Pull apart

COMMON MISTAKES

- Too heavy
- Leaning back

EASIER / HARDER

Band face pull / Pause at the end

SWAPS

Rear Delt Fly, Band Pull-Apart

Hammer Curl

Upper · Biceps, brachialis, forearms · Equipment: Dumbbells

SETUP

1. Stand tall holding dumbbells with palms facing each other.

EXECUTION

1. Curl up while keeping your elbows still.
2. Lower over 2–3 seconds.

CUES

- Elbows pinned

COMMON MISTAKES

- Swinging

EASIER / HARDER

Seated / Cross-body hammer curls

SWAPS

Rope Cable Curl

Incline DB Press

Upper · Upper chest, front delts, triceps · Equipment: Adjustable bench, dumbbells

SETUP

1. Set the bench to 30° (two or three notches).
2. Kick the dumbbells up and set your shoulder blades back and down.

EXECUTION

1. Lower the dumbbells to your upper chest with elbows about 45°.
2. Press up and slightly in.

CUES

- Low incline — 30°
- Shoulder blades pinned

COMMON MISTAKES

- Bench too steep (becomes a shoulder press)
- Elbows flaring

EASIER / HARDER

Incline Machine Press / Pause at the bottom

SWAPS

Incline Barbell Press, Incline Machine Press

Lat Pulldown

Upper · Lats, mid-back, biceps · Equipment: Lat pulldown machine

SETUP

1. Adjust the thigh pad so your legs are locked in snugly.
2. Grab the bar slightly wider than shoulder-width with an overhand grip.

EXECUTION

1. Lean back about 10–15° and lift your chest.
2. Pull the bar to your upper chest by driving your elbows down toward your back pockets.
3. Squeeze your lats for a moment, then let the bar rise slowly until your arms are straight and your shoulders stretch up.

CUES

- Elbows to back pockets
- Chest up to meet the bar
- Full stretch at the top

COMMON MISTAKES

- Pulling with the arms and biceps only
- Swinging the torso back for momentum
- Pulling the bar behind the neck
- Cutting the stretch at the top

EASIER / HARDER

Band-Assisted Pull-Up or lighter weight / Pull-Ups or 3-sec lowering

SWAPS

Assisted Pull-Up, Single-Arm Cable Pulldown, Pull-Ups

Machine Chest Press

Upper · Pecs, triceps, front delts · Equipment: Chest press machine

SETUP

1. Adjust the seat so the handles line up with your mid-chest.

EXECUTION

1. Press the handles forward without locking hard.
2. Return slowly until you feel a stretch in your chest.

CUES

- Shoulder blades back
- Control the return

COMMON MISTAKES

- Seat too high or low
- Shoulders rolling forward

EASIER / HARDER

Lighter weight / Single-arm press

SWAPS

DB Chest Press, Push-Ups

Overhead Tricep Extension

Upper · Triceps (long head) · Equipment: Dumbbell or cable

SETUP

1. Hold one dumbbell overhead with both hands, sitting or standing tall.

EXECUTION

1. Lower the dumbbell behind your head by bending your elbows.
2. Extend back to the top, keeping your elbows pointing forward.

CUES

- Elbows forward
- Deep stretch

COMMON MISTAKES

- Elbows flaring wide
- Arching the back

EASIER / HARDER

Cable overhead extension / Slower lowering

SWAPS

Skull Crushers

Paused DB Bench Press

Upper · Pecs, triceps, front delts · Equipment: Bench, dumbbells

SETUP

1. Same setup as the DB Chest Press, using about 80% of your normal working weight.

EXECUTION

1. Lower to the bottom and hold perfectly still for 2 seconds.
2. Press explosively without bouncing.

CUES

- Freeze at the bottom
- Explode up

COMMON MISTAKES

- Relaxing at the bottom and losing position

EASIER / HARDER

1-second pause / 3-second pause

SWAPS

DB Chest Press with 3-sec lowering

Push-Ups

Upper · Pecs, triceps, front delts, core · Equipment: Bodyweight

SETUP

1. Hands slightly wider than shoulders, body in a straight line from head to heels.

EXECUTION

1. Lower your chest toward the floor with elbows at about 45°.
2. Push the floor away to return to the top.

CUES

- Plank while you push
- Chest leads, hips follow

COMMON MISTAKES

- Sagging hips
- Half reps
- Elbows flared at 90°

EASIER / HARDER

Incline push-ups on a bench, or knees / Deficit or weighted push-ups

SWAPS

DB Chest Press

Rear Delt Fly

Upper · Rear delts, upper back · Equipment: Dumbbells or reverse pec deck

SETUP

1. Hinge forward with a flat back, holding light dumbbells under your chest.

EXECUTION

1. Raise your arms out to the sides with a soft bend in the elbows.
2. Squeeze at the top, then lower slowly.

CUES

- Reverse hug
- Pinkies lead

COMMON MISTAKES

- Using the traps
- Swinging

EASIER / HARDER

Chest supported on an incline bench / Cable rear delt fly

SWAPS

Reverse Pec Deck, Face Pulls

Single-Arm DB Row

Upper · Lats, mid-back, rear delts · Equipment: Bench, dumbbell

SETUP

1. Place one knee and the same-side hand on a bench, back flat.
2. Hold a dumbbell in the other hand, arm hanging straight.

EXECUTION

1. Pull the dumbbell toward your hip, driving your elbow back.
2. Squeeze your back at the top.
3. Lower slowly to a full stretch.

CUES

- Pull to your hip, not your chest
- Flat back

COMMON MISTAKES

- Twisting the torso
- Pulling with the bicep

EASIER / HARDER

Chest-supported row / Pause at the top

SWAPS

Seated Cable Row

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Foundation phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2–3 · 2 min				☐
Incline DB Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2–3 · 2 min				☐
DB Shoulder Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Bench Dips 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Push-Ups 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Foundation phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 3 × 10 · RIR 2–3 · 2 min				☐
Single-Arm DB Row 3 × 10 /side · RIR 2–3 · 2 min				☐
Face Pulls 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Rear Delt Fly 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Hammer Curl 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 3 · Volume Push

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Foundation phase · Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
Paused DB Bench Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2–3 · 2 min				☐
Machine Chest Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Cable Fly 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Arnold Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Foundation phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2 · 2 min				☐
Incline DB Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2 · 2 min				☐
DB Shoulder Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Bench Dips 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Push-Ups 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

WEEK 2 · LOG

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Foundation phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 3 × 10 · RIR 2 · 2 min				☐
Single-Arm DB Row 3 × 10 /side · RIR 2 · 2 min				☐
Face Pulls 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Rear Delt Fly 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Hammer Curl 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 3 · Volume Push

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Foundation phase · Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	✓
Paused DB Bench Press 3 × 10 · RIR 2 · 2 min				☐
Machine Chest Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Cable Fly 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Arnold Press 3 × 12 · RIR 2 · 75s				☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 2 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s				☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Build phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 4 × 8 · RIR 2 · 2.5 min					☐
Incline DB Press 4 × 8 · RIR 2 · 2.5 min					☐
DB Shoulder Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Bench Dips 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Push-Ups 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0–1 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Build phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 4 × 8 · RIR 2 · 2.5 min					☐
Single-Arm DB Row 4 × 8 /side · RIR 2 · 2.5 min					☐
Face Pulls 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Rear Delt Fly 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Hammer Curl 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0–1 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 3 · Volume Push

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Build phase · Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
Paused DB Bench Press 4 × 8 · RIR 2 · 2.5 min					☐
Machine Chest Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Cable Fly 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Arnold Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1–2 · 75s					☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0–1 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 1 · Heavy Push

WEEK 4 · LOG

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Build phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 4 × 8 · RIR 1–2 · 2.5 min					☐
Incline DB Press 4 × 8 · RIR 1–2 · 2.5 min					☐
DB Shoulder Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Bench Dips 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Push-Ups 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Build phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 4 × 8 · RIR 1–2 · 2.5 min					☐
Single-Arm DB Row 4 × 8 /side · RIR 1–2 · 2.5 min					☐
Face Pulls 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Rear Delt Fly 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Hammer Curl 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 3 · Volume Push

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

Build phase · Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
Paused DB Bench Press 4 × 8 · RIR 1–2 · 2.5 min					☐
Machine Chest Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Cable Fly 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Arnold Press 3 × 10 · RIR 1 · 75s					☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 3 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Strength phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	SET 5 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 5 × 5 · RIR 1–2 · 3 min						☐
Incline DB Press 5 × 5 · RIR 1–2 · 3 min						☐
DB Shoulder Press 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Bench Dips 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Push-Ups 2 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s						☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Strength phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	SET 5 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 5 × 5 · RIR 1–2 · 3 min						☐
Single-Arm DB Row 5 × 5 /side · RIR 1–2 · 3 min						☐
Face Pulls 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Rear Delt Fly 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Hammer Curl 2 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s						☐

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Day 3 · Volume Push

Date _____ Bodyweight _____ Energy (1–10) _____ Sleep (hrs) _____

Strength phase · Paused presses and isolation for volume.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	SET 5 LB × REPS	✓
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Cable Fly 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Arnold Press 3 × 8–10 · RIR 1–2 · 90s						☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 2 × AMRAP · RIR 0 · 60s						☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

Day 1 · Heavy Push

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

PR Week phase · Heavy pressing: the main strength day.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
DB Chest Press 4 × Heavy 3 · RIR 1 · 3 min					☐
Incline DB Press 4 × Heavy 3 · RIR 1 · 3 min					☐
DB Shoulder Press 2 × 10 · RIR 2 · 90s					☐
Bench Dips 2 × 10 · RIR 2 · 90s					☐
Push-Ups 1 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐

Total sets

New PR?

Day 2 · Pull + Posture

Date	Bodyweight	Energy (1–10)	Sleep (hrs)

PR Week phase · A strong back builds a stronger press.

EXERCISE	SET 1 LB × REPS	SET 2 LB × REPS	SET 3 LB × REPS	SET 4 LB × REPS	✓
Lat Pulldown 4 × Heavy 3 · RIR 1 · 3 min					☐
Single-Arm DB Row 4 × Heavy 3 /side · RIR 1 · 3 min					☐
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Total sets

New PR?

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Machine Chest Press 2 × 10 · RIR 2 · 90s					☐
Cable Fly 2 × 10 · RIR 2 · 90s					☐
Arnold Press 2 × 10 · RIR 2 · 90s					☐
Overhead Tricep Extension 1 × AMRAP · RIR 1 · 60s					☐

WARM-UP NOTES

HOW DID IT FEEL? WHAT WILL YOU CHANGE NEXT TIME?

Workout complete ☐ Total sets _____ New PR? _____

PR Log

Estimated 1RM = weight × (1 + reps ÷ 30).

LIFT	DATE	WEIGHT	REPS	EST. 1RM	NOTES